

I figured it was time to move on.

The inner need was like a seismic fissure deep in the rock under a ski run. Resort owners treat the fissure by dynamiting the mountain. The blast causes a mild, controlled snow slide but releases pressure on the rock. The alternative—to do nothing—may work for a while. But sooner or later there'll be an avalanche and almost certain disaster.

When you reach the anxiety of midlife plateau, you're the fissure in the rock. You can blast yourself into a new mountain. Or you can suffocate in the crushing avalanche of middle management, hoping for the vaguely defined big break somewhere down the line.

KICKING THE WORK HABIT

How hard will it be to cash in your chips when the time comes? To schedule that final meeting with the boss? To walk out of the office for the last time?

Let me put it as simply as I can. It may be the hardest thing you'll ever do.

You'll recall that the three-part formula for retiring is:

Do your arithmetic

Do some soul-searching

Do what you want

Of the three, the second was by far the most difficult for me. Vicki and I spent almost two years making the decision. We went over it and over it, with friends, psychologists, and almost everyone else we could confide in. We were *certain* we were making the right move. But I was terrified before the final jump. I felt alone and vulnerable. I dreaded the consequences if I was wrong.

But the big day finally came and I went for it. The talk with the boss lasted only a few minutes. As predicted by the bathtub test, the boss took my resignation in stride. I was just one more incident in his busy day.